

THE YOUNG BRIGADE

The seven stars of the 18th Lok Sabha for whom age is not a barrier to their ambition



IQRA CHOUDHARY, *29* ▶

| SAMAJWADI PARTY | *Kairana, UP*

Blessed with political pedigree as well as educational degrees, Iqra is exactly the kind of young parliamentarian a modern democracy needs. Her grandfather Akhtar Hasan, father Munawwar Hasan and mother Tabassum have all been parliamentarians, and Kairana has been something of a stronghold for the Muslim Gujjar family. After completing graduation from Lady Shriram College in Delhi, acquiring a law degree from Delhi University, Iqra went on to study International Politics and Law at the School of Oriental and African Studies, London. Her first political success came when her campaigning for her brother Nahid Hasan, who was in jail, saw him win the election. This time, she has won the election herself, defeating sitting MP and Jat leader Pradip Choudhary as well as the BJP's politics of polarisation that had reaped the party political dividend after the Hindu-Muslim riots of 2013. Iqra now hopes to begin a new chapter, enthused by the fact that all communities—Sainis, Gujjars, Jats, Rajputs, Dalits—voted for her, despite her being a Muslim, one of the 24 MPs from the community who will sit in the 18th Lok Sabha. Her list of priorities is long. "Kairana is near Delhi-NCR," she said in a media interview. "But we still do not have industries, medical colleges or PSUs here. I want these essential things to be here." She also wants to do something for women's empowerment, a tough ask given the patriarchal set-up that is typical of her very own constituency. Finally, there is the battle to rescue Kairana from the ignominy it was thrust into in 2013.

▶ SANJNA JATAV, *26*

| CONGRESS | *Bharatpur (SC), Rajasthan*



Her impromptu jig after winning the Bharatpur constituency has gone on to become an enduring symbol of the celebration of democracy. And though young in years, Sanjna has already achieved plenty in life. She was only 17 when she got married to police constable Kaptan Singh. Her in-laws encouraged her to finish her graduation and a law degree thereafter. And then her husband's elder uncle, who is the village sarpanch, and encouraged her to contest, and she did, becoming a zila parishad member in Kathumar village in 2021. A foray into the 2023 assembly election ended in disappointment, especially as Sanjna lost by a mere 400-odd